To be honest, and as I've touched upon, I've never felt any true sense of team spirit within the current team. But more on that in Chapter 10.

As a counterpoint, my role in and relationship with the Cape Cobras is totally different. I've become a lot more outspoken in the Cobras set-up, for the simple reason that I love playing in a *team*. There are no issues in that team, no egos; everybody gets along well. It's a great team to play in, just like Glamorgan, my county club. There are no damn status and ego issues, man.

That's why I've just never bothered speaking my mind in the South African team. In 1999 I was still fairly new and had only been playing for two years. But that, by the way, was a *real* team; there were no dramas. Everybody got on like a house on fire.

I know there are people in the squad with whom Vinnie hasn't always quite seen eye to eye. I know that one or two players think, 'Well, Vinnie didn't play international cricket, so what has he got to offer?' Proteas fast bowler Makhaya Ntini, however, would be the first to tell you how valuable Vinnie's cricketing input is. Same applies to our off-spinner, Johan Botha.

Vinnie has been a figure far more valuable than a coach to me. He's been more like a best mate, an older brother and a father figure rolled into one. Vinnie is just great to talk to, and I can offload whatever's in my heart and on my mind when I need advice on relationships and other personal stuff.

Hansie Cronjé

If there's one name mine will always be linked with, it is Wessel Johannes Cronjé's. And yes, the match-fixing scandal may have cuffed us together, but Hansie was a man I will always admire. He had his faults, I know. When he accepted money from bookies, he deserved the censure his actions received. If he were still alive, Hansie would undoubtedly be the first to admit that.

I am often asked whether I ever forgave Hansie for the whole drama. Of course I did. I mean, I was an adult too, and I take responsibility for my decisions. What there was to forgive, I forgave him for long ago. I don't hold any grudges at all. People make mistakes, and I, of all people, am not going to be the one pointing fingers, that's for sure. Hansie was human; he made a serious blunder, but I dare you to put your hand up if you've never made a serious mistake in your life. Hansie's was a very public mistake, and the consequences were far-reaching, but I don't think any of us on this